A 31-DAY PRAYER & MEDITATION COMPANION

Finding Christ in the Darkness

Thirty-one days of Psalms, Gospel words, and prayer
for the soul that feels lost and is looking for Christ's compassion.

"The Lord is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit." — Psalm 34:18

Inspired by the themes and daily arc of Edward T. Welch's devotional, Depression: Finding Christ in the Darkness (P&R Publishing, 2024).[1] All reflections, prayers, and action steps in this companion are original and are not excerpts from Welch's text.

If you are in crisis or thinking about ending your life, please reach out now: call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, US) or go to your nearest emergency room. You do not have to face this alone.

HOW TO USE THIS COMPANION

A Guide for the Weary Soul

This companion walks through four movements, following the same arc found in Ed Welch's 31-day devotional: Darkness Intrudes (Days 1–2) names the weight you feel without shame; Spiritual Realities (Days 3–19) anchors your soul in what is true about God, faith, and Christ even when nothing feels true; Accomplices (Days 20–27) faces the failure, shame, fear, anger, and loss that often travel with depression; and Hope (Days 28–31) waits for the joy Christ promises is still coming.

Each day pairs one short reflection with a Psalm or a word from the Gospels, followed by a written prayer and a small, doable step — the kind of "next right thing" that is realistic on a hard day. There is a checkbox beside each part. You are not being graded. Check only what you can do; leave the rest, and try again tomorrow.

Move at whatever pace you need. Repeat a day if it helped. Skip a day if you truly cannot. Read a day out loud if it's easier to hear it than to read it silently. If possible, ask someone you trust to walk through a few days with you — isolation tends to deepen darkness, and being with even one other person is part of how healing happens.

> Today's Practice — the checklist on each page includes: reading the Scripture slowly (aloud if you can), sitting with the reflection, praying the written prayer or your own version of it, taking today's small step, and noting one honest thought.

1. Book overview drawn from publicly available descriptions and tables of contents at ccef.org/book/depression-finding-christ-in-the-darkness and opc.org (Ordained Servant review). This companion is an independent devotional resource and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Edward T. Welch, CCEF, or P&R Publishing. Scripture quotations are from the World English Bible (WEB), which is in the public domain.

AT A GLANCE

31-Day Tracker

Check off each day as you go, or use this page to plan which day you'll begin.

DONE	DAY	REFLECTION	SCRIPTURE
	1	You Are Not the First	*Psalm 42:5-6*
	2	Why Am I Depressed?	*Psalm 13:1-2*
	3	Life and Death	*John 11:25-26*
	4	"Who Do You Say That I Am?"	*Matthew 16:15-16*
	5	Words	*John 6:68*
	6	Speak	*Psalm 142:1-2*
	7	Lies	*John 8:31-32*
	8	Faith	*Mark 9:23-24*
	9	Ask	*Matthew 7:7-8*
	10	Confess	*Psalm 32:3-5*
	11	Small Things	*Matthew 25:21*
	12	Today	*Matthew 6:34*
	13	Do You Belong to God?	*John 10:27-29*
	14	Little Faith	*Matthew 14:29-31*
	15	Faith Tested	*Psalm 66:10-12*
	16	Ransomed	*Mark 10:45*
	17	Not Your Own	*Luke 15:4-6*
	18	"Why, O Lord?"	*Psalm 22:1-2*
	19	Be a Psalmist	*Psalm 88:1-3*
	20	Failure	*John 21:15-17*
	21	Law	*Matthew 11:28-30*
	22	Shame	*Psalm 34:4-5*
	23	Regrets	*Psalm 51:10-12*
	24	Fear and Anxiety	*Psalm 56:3-4*
	25	Anger	*Psalm 4:4*
	26	Purpose	*John 15:5*
	27	Loss	*John 11:33-35*
	28	A Cloud of Witnesses	*Psalm 121:1-2*
	29	"Waiting, I Waited"	*Psalm 40:1-3*
	30	Just a Little While	*John 16:20-22*
	31	I Believe	*John 20:27-29*

You Are Not the First

PSALM 42:5-6

> *Why are you in despair, my soul? Why are you disturbed within me? Hope in God! For I shall still praise him for the saving help of his presence. My God, my soul is in despair within me. Therefore I remember you from the land of the Jordan, the heights of Hermon, from the hill Mizar.*

Some of the godliest people in Scripture wept, groaned, and felt cast down — David among them. If you feel heavy today, you are not failing at faith; you are in company with the psalmists, the prophets, and even Jesus in Gethsemane. Depression is not proof God has left you. It is proof you are human, in a broken world, still able to feel. Let today simply be about naming the weight without pretending it isn't there.

A PRAYER

Lord, I don't have words to explain why everything feels so heavy. Thank you that David felt this way too, and you didn't turn from him. Meet me here, in the honest middle of my "why," and remind me that hoping in you is still possible even now.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 42:5-6, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write one honest sentence describing how you actually feel today — no editing, no performing.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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Why Am I Depressed?

PSALM 13:1-2

> *How long, Yahweh? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me? How long shall I take counsel in my soul, having sorrow in my heart every day? How long shall my enemy triumph over me?*

David asks "How long?" four times in two verses — he doesn't pretend the delay doesn't hurt. Asking why you feel this way is not weak faith; it's the start of an honest conversation with a God who already knows the answer and isn't offended by the question. You don't need a tidy explanation before you're allowed to pray. Bring the question itself as your prayer.

A PRAYER

God, I don't fully understand why this darkness has settled over me. I bring you my "how long" today, trusting you can handle my honesty better than my silence.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 13:1-2, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: List, without judging yourself, any recent losses, changes, or burdens that may be part of this season.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Life and Death

JOHN 11:25-26

> *Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in me will still live, even if he dies. Whoever lives and believes in me will never die. Do you believe this?"*

Jesus doesn't just offer information about life after death — he claims to BE the resurrection and the life, present tense, right now. When everything in you feels like it's dying — hope, energy, joy — Christ is not far off waiting for heaven to fix it; he is near, holding the very life you feel you've lost. The question he asked Martha, he asks you: "Do you believe this?" You don't need a perfect yes, just a willing one.

A PRAYER

Jesus, so much in me feels like it's dying today. Be the resurrection and the life for me right now, even in this tired body and heart. I want to believe — help the unbelieving parts of me.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 11:25-26, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Say out loud, "Jesus, you are the resurrection and the life," even if you don't feel it yet.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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"Who Do You Say That I Am?"

MATTHEW 16:15-16

> *He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?" Simon Peter answered, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."*

Depression can quietly rewrite who you believe Jesus is — distant, disappointed, indifferent. Today's question isn't about your feelings toward Christ, but about who he actually is regardless of the fog. Peter's answer wasn't produced by good feelings; it was revealed to him by the Father. You can borrow Peter's words even when your own heart feels flat.

A PRAYER

Jesus, on my best days and my hardest ones, you are still the Christ, the Son of the living God. Help me answer this question with truth today, not just with how I feel.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Matthew 16:15-16, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write down three things you know to be true about Jesus, regardless of your emotions.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Words

JOHN 6:68

> *Simon Peter answered him, "Lord, to whom would we go? You have the words of eternal life."*

When the crowds walked away from Jesus' hard teaching, Peter didn't stay because he understood everything or felt inspired — he stayed because there was nowhere else to go. Depression often strips away every other comfort until this same question remains: Lord, to whom shall I go? There is real relief in admitting Jesus' words are the only place that holds real life, even when you can't feel it yet.

A PRAYER

Lord, I don't have anywhere else to go either. Even when I can't feel your words working in me, I choose to stay near them today.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 6:68, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Read one short psalm or Gospel passage slowly, aloud, even if your mind wanders.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Speak

PSALM 142:1-2

> *I cry with my voice to Yahweh. With my voice, I ask Yahweh for mercy. I pour out my complaint before him. I tell him my troubles.*

This psalm was written from a cave, at the end of the writer's strength — and instead of hiding his complaint, he pours it out loud to God. You don't have to soften your words for God to receive them. Speaking your trouble to him, even in raw, unpolished language, is itself an act of faith, because it treats him as someone who is actually listening.

A PRAYER

Lord, I pour out my complaint before you today — not because you don't know it, but because I need to say it. Hear me.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 142:1-2, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Set a timer for five minutes and tell God everything that's wrong, out loud or in writing, without filtering.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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Lies

JOHN 8:31-32

> *Jesus therefore said to those Jews who had believed him, "If you remain in my word, then you are truly my disciples. You will know the truth, and the truth will make you free."*

Depression often speaks in absolutes: always, never, no one, nothing will change. Jesus offers something different — not a pep talk, but truth that actually sets people free, born of continually abiding in his word rather than in the darkness's narration. Freedom doesn't usually arrive all at once; it comes as you keep returning to what is true, one lie at a time.

A PRAYER

Jesus, help me tell the difference between what depression is saying and what is actually true. Set me free, even in small increments today.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 8:31-32, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Identify one lie depression keeps repeating to you, and write the truth from Scripture that answers it.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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Faith

MARK 9:23-24

> *Jesus said to him, "If you can believe, all things are possible to him who believes." Immediately the father of the child cried out with tears, "I believe. Help my unbelief!"*

The father in this story didn't have strong faith — he had honest faith, believing and doubting in the very same breath. Jesus didn't turn him away for the doubt; he healed the boy anyway. You do not need to manufacture certainty before Christ will meet you; "I believe, help my unbelief" is itself a real prayer of faith.

A PRAYER

Jesus, I believe — and I need help with everything in me that doubts. Meet me in the middle of my mixed, honest faith today.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Mark 9:23-24, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Pray this simple prayer aloud three times today: "I believe; help my unbelief."
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Ask

MATTHEW 7:7-8

> *"Ask, and it will be given you. Seek, and you will find. Knock, and it will be opened for you. For everyone who asks receives. He who seeks finds. To him who knocks it will be opened."*

Jesus' invitation is startlingly simple: ask, seek, knock. He doesn't say ask only if you feel worthy, or ask only once. Depression can make asking feel pointless, as if the door is already closed — but Jesus describes a Father who opens doors, not one who waits behind them in silence. Today, let yourself ask for something specific, however small.

A PRAYER

Father, I'm asking. I don't know if I'll feel an answer right away, but I'm knocking anyway, because you said to.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Matthew 7:7-8, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Ask God for one specific thing you need today — comfort, sleep, strength, a friend — and say it plainly.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Confess

PSALM 32:3-5

> *When I kept silence, my bones wasted away through my groaning all day long. For day and night your hand was heavy on me. My strength was sapped in the heat of summer. Selah. I acknowledged my sin to you. I didn't hide my iniquity. I said, I will confess my transgressions to Yahweh, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin. Selah.*

David describes the physical toll of carrying unconfessed weight — bones wasting, strength drained — and then the relief the moment he stopped hiding and told God the truth. Confession isn't only about sin narrowly defined; it's about refusing to carry alone what was never meant to be carried alone. Whatever you've been hiding — resentment, doubt, a hard thought about God — bring it into the light today.

A PRAYER

Lord, I don't want to hide anything from you anymore. I confess what I've been carrying silently, and I receive your forgiveness and relief.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 32:3-5, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Confess one specific thing to God in prayer — and if you can, to one trusted person as well.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Small Things

MATTHEW 25:21

> *"His lord said to him, 'Well done, good and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a few things, I will set you over many things. Enter into the joy of your lord.'"*

Jesus commends faithfulness in small things long before he mentions great ones — a reminder that the tiny, unnoticed acts of today are not beneath his notice. When depression makes even small tasks feel like climbing a mountain, doing one small faithful thing is not insignificant to Christ; it is exactly the kind of faithfulness he delights in. You don't have to do everything today. Just the next small thing.

A PRAYER

Jesus, help me be faithful in the small thing in front of me today, and trust you with the rest. Thank you that nothing done in faith is wasted on you.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Matthew 25:21, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Choose one small, doable task — a shower, a meal, a made bed — and do only that today.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Today

MATTHEW 6:34

> *Therefore don't be anxious for tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself. Each day's own evil is sufficient.*

Jesus doesn't ask you to solve tomorrow, next month, or the rest of your life today — only today has enough in it to carry. Depression often collapses the future into an unbearable weight held all at once; Jesus invites you to set that weight down and live inside this one day's grace instead. God's mercy comes new each morning, not all at once for a lifetime.

A PRAYER

Lord, I release tomorrow into your hands. Give me only what I need for today, and help me not to carry what isn't mine to carry yet.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Matthew 6:34, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write down one thing you are only responsible for today — nothing further out.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Do You Belong to God?

JOHN 10:27-29

> *My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me. I give eternal life to them. They will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand. My Father, who has given them to me, is greater than all. No one is able to snatch them out of my Father's hand.*

Jesus describes a grip that nothing can break — not even your own wavering feelings. Depression can make you feel forgotten or lost, but Jesus' promise here isn't based on how strongly you're holding on to him; it's based on his hand holding you. Belonging to God was never about your grip strength.

A PRAYER

Jesus, thank you that I am held by you, not by my own strength. Even on days I feel like I've let go, remind me that your hand hasn't.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 10:27-29, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write the words "no one can snatch me out of his hand" somewhere you'll see them today.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Little Faith

MATTHEW 14:29-31

> *He said, "Come!" Peter stepped down from the boat, and walked on the waters to come to Jesus. But when he saw that the wind was strong, he was afraid, and beginning to sink, he cried out, saying, "Lord, save me!" Immediately Jesus stretched out his hand, took hold of him, and said to him, "You of little faith, why did you doubt?"*

Peter took his eyes off Jesus for one moment and began to sink — and Jesus' response wasn't to let him drown as a lesson, but to reach out immediately and catch him. "Little faith" was enough for Jesus to save him; it didn't need to be great faith. Your small, sinking, barely-there faith today is enough for Jesus to reach for you.

A PRAYER

Lord, save me — my faith feels so small today. Thank you that you don't wait for great faith before you reach out your hand.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Matthew 14:29-31, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: When you feel yourself sinking today, say simply, "Lord, save me," and notice that this alone is a real prayer.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Faith Tested

PSALM 66:10–12

> *For you, God, have tested us. You have refined us, as silver is refined. You brought us into prison. You laid a burden on our backs. You allowed men to ride over our heads. We went through fire and through water, but you brought us to the place of abundance.*

This psalm doesn't shy away from describing real hardship — fire, water, burdens, being tested like silver. But it ends somewhere unexpected: a place of abundance. The psalmist doesn't deny the suffering was real; he trusts God was present in it and leading somewhere beyond it. Your testing is not a sign God has abandoned the process — it may be the very furnace he is using to refine what's true and lasting in you.

A PRAYER

God, this feels like fire and water today. I trust that you are refining, not abandoning me, and that you are leading me somewhere beyond this.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 66:10–12, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Name one way you have grown, or grown more honest with God, through this hard season.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Ransomed

MARK 10:45

> *For the Son of Man also came not to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."*

Jesus didn't come to be served by you, waiting for you to prove your worth before helping — he came to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for people exactly like you, in exactly this condition. You do not need to earn Christ's compassion by feeling better first. He came looking for you while you were still in the dark.

A PRAYER

Jesus, thank you that you came to serve me, not to wait for me to serve you first. I receive what you paid for me today, even in this weary state.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Mark 10:45, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Rest for ten minutes today without accomplishing anything, as an act of trusting you are ransomed, not earning worth.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Not Your Own

LUKE 15:4-6

> *"Which of you men, if you had one hundred sheep, and lost one of them, wouldn't leave the ninety-nine in the wilderness, and go after the one that was lost, until he found it? When he has found it, he carries it on his shoulders, rejoicing. When he comes home, he calls together his friends and his neighbors, saying to them, 'Rejoice with me, for I have found my sheep which was lost!'"*

The shepherd in this parable doesn't wait for the lost sheep to find its own way home — he goes after it, searches until he finds it, and carries it home rejoicing. If you feel lost today, this is not a story about you finding your way back to God through effort; it's a story about Christ coming to find you and carrying you himself. You belong to a Shepherd who goes looking.

A PRAYER

Good Shepherd, I feel like the one who wandered off today. Thank you for coming after me instead of waiting for me to find my own way back.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Luke 15:4-6, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Picture yourself being carried on Christ's shoulders today, and let that image sit with you for a few quiet minutes.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
  _____

“Why, O Lord?”

PSALM 22:1-2

> *My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from helping me, and from the words of my groaning? My God, I cry in the daytime, but you don’t answer; in the night season, and am not silent.*

These are the same words Jesus cried from the cross — the darkest human question, spoken by the Son of God himself. You are not asking anything Jesus hasn’t asked. He entered the full weight of feeling forsaken so you would never be truly alone in asking it, even when God feels silent.

A PRAYER

My God, my God, why do you feel so far away? Thank you that Jesus asked this too, and that you meet me in this very question rather than condemning it.

TODAY’S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today’s Scripture, Psalm 22:1-2, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today’s reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today’s prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today’s step: Read Psalm 22 in full, noticing how it moves from abandonment toward praise by its end.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Be a Psalmist

PSALM 88:1-3

> *Yahweh, the God of my salvation, I have cried day and night before you. Let my prayer enter into your presence. Turn your ear to my cry. For my soul is full of troubles. My life draws near to Sheol.*

Psalm 88 is unusual — it ends in darkness, with no resolved happy ending, and yet it remains addressed to God the whole way through. Sometimes the most faithful prayer is not a tidy conclusion but simply continuing to speak to God even when nothing has changed. You are allowed to write your own honest psalm today, unresolved and all.

A PRAYER

God of my salvation, I cry out to you day and night, even without answers yet. Let my prayer reach you, even in this unresolved place.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 88:1-3, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write your own short psalm today — your honest complaint, addressed directly to God.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Failure

JOHN 21:15-17

> *So when they had eaten their breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me more than these?" He said to him, "Yes, Lord; you know that I have affection for you." He said to him, "Feed my lambs." He said to him again a second time, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me?" He said to him, "Yes, Lord; you know that I have affection for you." He said to him, "Tend my sheep." He said to him the third time, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you have affection for me?" Peter was grieved because he asked him the third time, "Do you have affection for me?" He said to him, "Lord, you know everything. You know that I have affection for you." Jesus said to him, "Feed my sheep."*

Peter had denied Jesus three times, and Jesus' response wasn't distance or rejection but three gentle, specific questions and a fresh commission: feed my sheep. Christ doesn't discard people after failure; he restores them to purpose. Whatever you believe you have failed at, Jesus is not finished asking you the same question Peter got: "Do you love me?"

A PRAYER

Jesus, like Peter, I've failed. Thank you for restoring rather than discarding me — help me answer your question with a simple yes today.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 21:15-17, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Name one failure you've been carrying, and ask Jesus for restoration rather than punishing yourself further over it.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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Law

MATTHEW 11:28-30

> *"Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart; and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light."*

Jesus doesn't invite the strong and capable to come to him; he calls the weary and burdened, promising rest instead of more requirements. His yoke is easy and his burden light — not because life gets easy, but because he carries it with you, gently, rather than standing over you demanding more. If you're exhausted trying to be good enough, this invitation is for you specifically.

A PRAYER

Jesus, I'm weary and heavy-laden. I come to you today for rest, not more rules to keep. Teach me your gentle, humble heart.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Matthew 11:28-30, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Identify one "should" you've been carrying like law, and give it to Jesus instead of trying to fulfill it under your own strength today.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Shame

PSALM 34:4-5

> *I sought Yahweh, and he answered me, and delivered me from all my fears. They looked to him, and were radiant. Their faces shall never be covered with shame.*

The psalmist describes seeking God and being delivered from fear, and then something remarkable — those who look to him are radiant, their faces never covered with shame. Shame tells you to hide your face; God's presence has the opposite effect, lifting your face rather than covering it. Whatever shame you carry today, it is not the last word Christ speaks over you.

A PRAYER

Lord, I've been hiding my face in shame. Help me look to you instead, trusting that you lift my face rather than condemn it.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 34:4-5, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Look in a mirror today and say, "God is not ashamed of me," even if it feels strange.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
  _____

Regrets

PSALM 51:10–12

> *Create in me a clean heart, O God. Renew a right spirit within me. Don't throw me from your presence, and don't take your holy Spirit from me. Restore to me the joy of your salvation. Uphold me with a willing spirit.*

David wrote this after his worst failure, and instead of only asking for forgiveness, he asks for something bigger: a clean heart, a right spirit, the return of joy. Regret can trap you in rehearsing the past; David's prayer moves forward, asking God to restore what was lost rather than only erase what was wrong. Your regrets don't disqualify you from asking for a renewed, joyful heart today.

A PRAYER

Create in me a clean heart, O God. Restore to me the joy I've lost, and give me a willing spirit to move forward instead of staying stuck in regret.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 51:10–12, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write down one regret, then write David's prayer for a clean heart and restored joy underneath it, as your own.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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Fear and Anxiety

PSALM 56:3-4

> *When I am afraid, I will put my trust in you. In God, I praise his word. In God, I put my trust. I will not be afraid. What can flesh do to me?*

The psalmist names his fear plainly — "when I am afraid" — rather than pretending to be fearless, and then makes a decision independent of that fear: "I will put my trust in you." Trust here isn't the absence of fear; it's a choice made in the middle of it. You can be afraid and trusting at the very same time.

A PRAYER

Lord, I am afraid today. I choose to put my trust in you anyway, not because the fear is gone, but because you are bigger than it.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 56:3-4, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Say aloud, "When I am afraid, I will trust in you," each time anxious thoughts rise today.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Anger

PSALM 4:4

> *Stand in awe, and don't sin. Search your own heart on your bed, and be still. Selah.*

Scripture doesn't tell you to deny anger — it tells you to bring it honestly before God without letting it curdle into sin: search your own heart, and be still. Anger, including anger at God, at others, or at yourself, can be safely brought into his presence rather than stuffed down or acted out. Stillness with God is where anger can finally be examined honestly.

A PRAYER

Lord, I bring my anger to you today instead of hiding it or acting it out. Help me be still long enough to see what's really underneath it.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 4:4, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Sit in silence for five minutes, naming any anger to God honestly, without judgment.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Purpose

JOHN 15:5

> *I am the vine. You are the branches. He who remains in me, and I in him, the same bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing.*

Jesus doesn't ask you to produce fruit through sheer willpower; he asks you to remain connected to him, the vine, and lets the fruit come from that abiding. On days you cannot imagine having purpose or usefulness again, this verse quietly reframes the goal: not performance, but staying attached to Christ. Apart from him, striving accomplishes nothing anyway — so today, simply remain.

A PRAYER

Jesus, I don't have strength to produce anything today. Help me simply remain attached to you, and trust you with whatever fruit comes from that.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 15:5, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Do one thing today purely to stay connected to Jesus — prayer, a verse, silence — without worrying about outcomes.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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Loss

JOHN 11:33-35

> *When Jesus therefore saw her weeping, and the Jews weeping who came with her, he groaned in the spirit, and was troubled, and said, "Where have you laid him?" They told him, "Lord, come and see." Jesus wept.*

Jesus knew he was about to raise Lazarus from the dead — and he wept anyway at the tomb. Christ's compassion doesn't require a hopeless situation to feel real grief with you; he enters your loss even when he already holds the resolution. Your losses are not too small, or too resolved-someday, for Jesus to weep with you over them now.

A PRAYER

Jesus, thank you for weeping at loss even when you already knew the outcome. Weep with me over what I've lost, and let me feel your nearness in this grief.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 11:33-35, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Name a specific loss you're grieving, and picture Jesus standing with you at that "tomb," moved by what moves you.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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A Cloud of Witnesses

PSALM 121:1-2

> *I will lift up my eyes to the hills. Where does my help come from? My help comes from Yahweh, who made heaven and earth.*

The psalmist lifts his eyes to the hills — not because the hills save him, but because looking up reorients him toward where his help actually comes from: the Maker of heaven and earth. Depression narrows your gaze downward and inward; today, practice the simple, physical act of lifting your eyes, trusting that your help comes from outside yourself. Others who've walked this road before you have proven this same help is real.

A PRAYER

Lord, my help comes from you, maker of heaven and earth. Help me lift my eyes today instead of staying fixed on the darkness in front of me.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, Psalm 121:1-2, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Go outside if you can, and literally lift your eyes to the sky or hills for a few minutes.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
  _____

“Waiting, I Waited”

PSALM 40:1-3

> *I waited patiently for Yahweh. He turned to me, and heard my cry. He brought me up also out of a horrible pit, out of the miry clay. He set my feet on a rock, and gave me a firm place to stand. He has put a new song in my mouth, even praise to our God. Many shall see it, and fear, and shall trust in Yahweh.*

The Hebrew behind “I waited patiently” is closer to “waiting, I waited” — an image of active, ongoing waiting rather than passive resignation. The psalmist didn’t wait because it was easy; he waited because God had proven trustworthy, and eventually God turned, heard, and set his feet on rock. Your waiting is not wasted time; it is the very posture God meets with rescue.

A PRAYER

Lord, I am waiting for you, even when it feels slow. Turn to me, hear my cry, and set my feet on solid ground again.

TODAY’S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today’s Scripture, Psalm 40:1-3, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today’s reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today’s prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today’s step: Write down one place you feel stuck in the “miry clay,” and ask God specifically to set your feet on rock there.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
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Just a Little While

JOHN 16:20-22

> *Most certainly I tell you, that you will weep and lament, but the world will rejoice. You will be sorrowful, but your sorrow will be turned into joy. A woman, when she gives birth, has sorrow, because her time has come. But when she has delivered the child, she doesn't remember the anguish any more, for the joy that a human being is born into the world. Therefore you now have sorrow, but I will see you again, and your heart will rejoice, and no one will take your joy away from you.*

Jesus compares present sorrow to labor pains — real, sharp, all-consuming in the moment — but promises the sorrow will turn into a joy no one can take away. He doesn't minimize the pain of now; he simply promises it is not the final word. Whatever season of darkness you're in, Jesus says plainly: it is "a little while," even when it doesn't feel little.

A PRAYER

Jesus, this sorrow feels enormous right now. Thank you for promising it won't be forever, and that joy is still coming that no one can take from me.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 16:20-22, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write down one hope for what joy might look like on the other side of this season.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:
  _____

I Believe

JOHN 20:27-29

> *Then he said to Thomas, "Reach here your finger, and see my hands. Reach here your hand, and put it into my side. Don't be unbelieving, but believing." Thomas answered him, "My Lord and my God!" Jesus said to him, "Because you have seen me, you have believed. Blessed are those who have not seen, and have believed."*

Jesus didn't rebuke Thomas for doubting — he came back specifically for him, offering exactly the proof Thomas needed, meeting him in his honest unbelief. And yet the greater blessing is promised to those who believe without seeing: you, right now, reaching for faith without physical proof. Thomas's confession — "My Lord and my God" — can be your closing word for these thirty-one days too.

A PRAYER

My Lord and my God, thank you for meeting me in every doubt over these thirty-one days. I believe — help my unbelief, and carry me forward from here.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

- [ ] Read today's Scripture, John 20:27-29, slowly — aloud if you can.
- [ ] Sit quietly with today's reflection for a few minutes.
- [ ] Pray today's prayer, or speak it in your own words.
- [ ] Today's step: Write your own one-sentence statement of faith for today, in your own words, as a marker of where you are right now.
- [ ] One honest thought I want to remember from today:

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